

Similarly, your past spending doesn't define who you are now. Credit card debt, student loans, even the hobby you spent hundreds of dollars to start and never ended up doing, these things do not define the kind of spender you are. The spender/saver myth is a lie.

Spending is not a reflection of who you are.

Because spending is a skill.

Spending is a skill because skills can be learned and improved. Sure, there are people who are naturally better at some skills, but even someone less talented can work hard and become better than someone with talent who doesn't hone their skill.

If you've never thought of spending that way, it's not your fault or the fault of those around you for not telling you. Spending isn't taught as a skill—there are no fundamentals classes or specialized seminars. If spending is mentioned in a book, it's usually as a morally ambiguous sidekick to the superior wealth-building strategies of earning and investing (because why learn how to spend when you can just make a ton of money? Everyone can do it!).

Instead, we've been thrust into a world screaming at us to buy who we want to become. As teenagers, we're encouraged to take out an amount of debt for school with no credit check that no young person could get approved for at a Toyota dealership. And without a shred of guidance on how to spend it wisely. How am I supposed to know what costs are worthy of my limited resources?

How many times should I be going out each week?

How much should I spend on groceries?

How many lattes is too many?

How do I save on a car without sacrificing safety?

How do I enjoy takeout without draining my bank account?

How do I buy what I love without going broke?!

Spending money is not the enemy of financial freedom. Spending is essential. It's a skill, not a character flaw. Even homesteaders living off the grid have monthly expenses! And when you separate your spending from your identity and view it as a skill to refine, then you can learn how to practice spending in a way that feels good and completely guilt free.